



OpenID

What is OpenID?

It is an identity key to access Web sites you need to log in to without the need to remember usernames and passwords and without needing to register.

Who developed it?

It was originally developed by Brad Fitzpatrick of LiveJournal, and is now being developed by everyone who is interested in working on the project.

How does it work?

Roughly, the user registers on an OpenID provider's site such as MyOpenID. These providers are referred to as i-brokers. Once registered, he receives a URL that will be his identity, for example, yourname.pip.verisignlabs.com. Now when he wants to log in to the OpenID-enabled site, the user types in this URL and clicks "login," which in turn takes him to an authorisation request page on the i-broker's site, where he enters his password. The i-broker site thus confirms that the user wants to be identified by the OpenID-enabled site, and the user gets logged in.

Where can this be used?

OpenID can be used wherever there is a need for identification. Some sites that have implemented OpenID are jyte.com, Wikipedia, ma.gnolia.com, and AOL.

When can one host an OpenID login on their site?

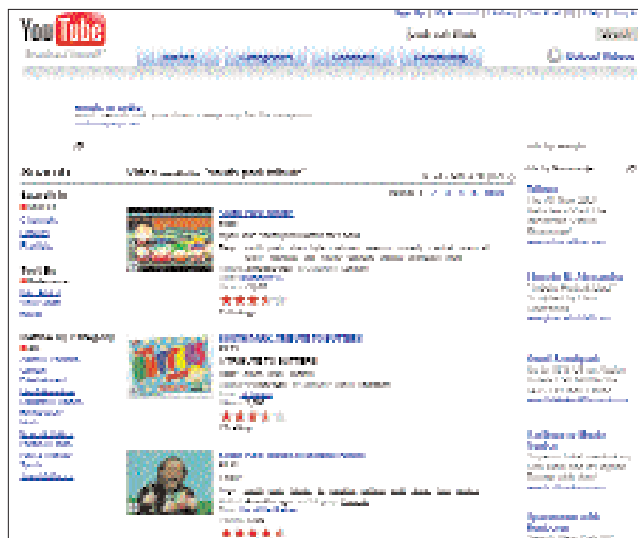
Anyone can run OpenID on their site right now, and can also host an OpenID server without having to pay anybody. Just four lines of code have to be included in the site code for a OpenID-based login, and the code is not JavaScript; it works on AJAX.

Why is this good?

Obviously, since the user has a single point of login (the i-broker's site), he need not remember different usernames and passwords. Also, one can log in to sites without registering.

say Yahoo!'s free Geocities servers, no one can sue Yahoo!. Makes sense, doesn't it? The catch phrase in this law is that the service provider must stop the wrong doing when informed of it. So although it is not the service provider's duty to check everything on its servers before it goes up, it is obliged to remove anything that it receives complaints about.

If Viacom wins its lawsuit, it will sure set off a whole range of other lawsuits, with innocent service providers getting sued. Is it really possible for a site as big as YouTube to monitor *all* its content?



Viacom seems to be saying, you have my content up there, remove it and make sure it doesn't happen again. Here's where the proverbial grey area steps in. Should a service provider hamper the services it provides to try and prevent wrong doing, or should the owner of the copyrights have to shoulder the responsibility of repeatedly checking for copyright infringement. The law is unclear: YouTube (basically Google) says Viacom should check and inform it, and then it will gladly remove the content, while Viacom says it's Google's duty to prevent repeated offences by various users by putting

up a filtering system.

Now Google has already struck deals with bigger companies such as NBC, to provide promos and clips to promote shows. Although NBC did start off by writing a little hate mail to YouTube, it soon figured out the benefits of partnering with it. A lot of people have learnt about new shows from YouTube rather than from the channel itself. That's what happens when you have an embarrassment of choices.

What's fishy to us is the fact that although such content has been uploaded for a while now, it's only now that Viacom has put in a lawsuit.

speculations are being made about the terms. We know what we'd like to see though: Google deciding to get into the cable TV business and spending some of their billions on buying one.

More recently, however, activist groups got together and sued Viacom for asking Google to remove a particular video. Apparently, this video, created by small-time movie makers Brave New Films and MoveOn.org does have a few clips from The Colbert Report, but only because it parodies it. The lawsuit claims that this is completely legal, and involves "fair use" of clips from a TV show. The lawsuit also states that Viacom should know "fair use" when it comes across it, but deliberately got Google to remove the video. This is a violation of freedom, which as we all know, can amount to a very serious and expensive crime in the US.

The latest lawsuit does not mention Google or YouTube, so they are being treated as a service provider in this case—which might actually help their cause in the lawsuit by Viacom. As far as Google is concerned, it's just a case of, "Hey, don't look at me, they told me to remove it!"

All this makes us marvel at the idea that is YouTube: it truly is more of a public run, video superpower, and less of another Google venture—thus far.

Events are so precariously poised right now, that everyone is taking notice. If Viacom does lose the battle with both Google as well as the latest lawsuit by the film makers, it might send a message out to the world: "You mess with Google, you mess with us!" It also tells bigger corporations to not mess with the little people of the online world—we're little, but we have nasty bites. Something tells us there's going to be more suing in this little controversy—hurrah for lawsuits, the great levellers of our time. ■